PARTICIPANT HANDOUT | LESSON 15

Romans Part 1

God Justifies the Ungodly

BIG IDEA All people stand guilty under sin, but God reveals his righteousness by justifying sinners through faith in Jesus Christ, leaving no room for boasting.

Series location: Lesson 15 of 24 | Romans 1-4

Primary texts: Romans 1:16-17; 3:9-26; 4:1-5, 16-25

Controlling question: How can God be righteous and justify the guilty?

Follow Paul's argument

PASSAGE	MOVEMENT
1:16-17	The gospel reveals God's righteousness and saves everyone who believes.
1:18-3:20	Every group stands under sin; every mouth is silenced before God.
3:21-31	God justifies by grace through faith because Christ has dealt with sin.
4:1-25	Abraham shows that the promise is received by faith and belongs to all who believe.

Every mouth is silenced

PAUL ADDRESSES	THE ESCAPE ROUTE HE CLOSES
Humanity exchanging worship for idols	Created things cannot replace the Creator, and chosen disorder brings judgment.
The moral judge	Condemning another person does not excuse the same sinner.
The person possessing God's law	Hearing and possessing the law are not the same as obeying it.
The whole world	No one is justified by works of the law; the law brings knowledge of sin.

Romans 1 is not ammunition for one group to condemn another. Romans 2 turns the accusation toward the accuser, and Romans 3 places everyone together under sin.

God's saving action in Christ

TERM	MEANING IN ROMANS 3
Justification	God's gracious verdict that the believer is in the right before him.
Grace	God gives what sinners cannot earn or demand.
Redemption	Christ liberates sinners at the cost of his own life.
Sacrifice of atonement	Christ's death deals with sin and demonstrates God's justice.
Faith	Trusting God's promise fulfilled in Jesus rather than presenting our own merit.

God is both just and the one who justifies those who have faith in Jesus. The cross means that forgiveness is neither denial nor indifference toward evil.

BEFORE NEXT WEEK Read Romans 5-8. Mark every reference to Adam, Christ, sin, death, life, the Spirit, suffering, and hope.

Abraham believed God's promise

WHAT HAPPENED	WHY IT MATTERS
Abraham's faith was credited as righteousness	The verdict was a gift, not wages for work.
He was declared righteous before circumcision	He can be father of Gentile believers as well as Jewish believers.
He trusted God when fulfillment looked impossible	Faith rests on the God who gives life to the dead and keeps his word.
His story was written also for us	God credits righteousness to those who trust the God who raised Jesus.

Discuss

1. Why does Paul take so much time to show that every group is under sin?
2. How can God forgive guilty people without becoming unjust?
3. How does Abraham's story challenge both religious pride and hopelessness?

FOR FURTHER STUDY
BibleProject, Romans 1-4 overview
Related: Genesis 15:1-6; Habakkuk 2:4; Psalm 32:1-2
ECO: Essential Tenet III.A | Class resources: scan QR.